

OUR OWN LETHAL HUNTERS

THE ADVENT OF LETHALLY ARMED DRONES WILL IMMEASURABLY ENHANCE THE INDIAN MILITARY'S SURVEILLANCE AND STRIKE OPTIONS. THE FOCUS IS NOW FOR THE BUSTLING INDIGENOUS DRONE INDUSTRY TO TAKE UP THE CHALLENGE

When India commemorates its 100th year of independence, could we see indigenous drones, fearsome in both offence and defence and among the best in the world, patrol the skies, deterring adversaries from any attempts at redrawing borders? No doubt, this is something that goads India's feverishly evolving drone sector on towards greater heights.

For their superb intelligence, surveillance & reconnaissance capabilities (ISR) as well for their armed strike options, drones are turning out to be an irreplaceable element in modern warfare. In the Ukraine conflict, the role of armed drones in thwarting the initial Russian attacks, and then their use by both sides to target military and civilian assets and infrastructure indicate how these machines might further evolve in lethality.

To scale up its surveillance and strike capabilities, especially along its border with China in the Himalayan heights, India is procuring 31 MQ-9B SeaGuardian and SkyGuardian drones, manufactured by San Diego-based General Atomics and worth $3 billion (around Rs 24,500 crore)—for the army, navy and air force.

WHY IT IS A GAME CHANGER

The navy had leased two MQ-9A drones from the US in November 2020. By November 2022, they had covered over 14 million square miles of operating area—much of it over the Line of Actual Control (LAC). It was the first time India used a drone of this calibre. Known as 'Hunter Killers', the MQ-9Bs provide unmatched surveillance and are armed with air-to-ground (Hellfire), air-to-air (Sidewinder and Stinger) missiles and smart bombs to hunt and destroy targets. The MQ-9Bs can be